

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN JERSEY

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

When the derelict Plémont holiday camp on Jersey's north-west coast — eleven and a half acres of coastal headland beside the last puffin colony on the island — was slated for housing, and consent for twenty-eight homes was granted in 2012, islanders did not accept the loss of one of the island's finest stretches of coast. Led by the **National Trust for Jersey**, they had already campaigned for over a decade; now they pressed on, through the States Assembly and the public, until a different path opened. The Trust agreed to buy the site; the States voted to fund half the purchase; the Trust raised the rest; and the headland was bought, the buildings demolished, and the land returned to nature. After fourteen years of campaigning, a place cleared for houses became an open, wild headland for everyone, forever. The lesson is distinctly Jersey: a community here can save a treasured place even after losing the planning battle.

A community in Jersey facing a harmful development works with genuinely strong tools, in a small, close-knit, rule-of-law island democracy. The first line is the **planning system and its objections and public-inquiry process** — a real gate, though, as Plémont shows, one a community can lose. Ecological and coastal value can be defended through **environmental and ecological assessment and designations** — the puffin colony, the scarce coast. The **States Assembly** is an accessible political route that can vote public funds and shift a decision; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. The distinctive Jersey lever is the **National Trust for Jersey and the buyout-and-restoration** it can lead: a respected conservation body that can acquire and hold land can save a site even one with planning consent — buying it, demolishing, and returning it to nature, as it did at Plémont. And a **small island's love of its scarce, treasured coast** mobilises powerfully. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The planning fight can be lost — at Plémont, after years of applications and a public inquiry, consent was granted. The buyout that saved it required raising over eight million pounds, roughly half of it public money voted by the States, which was genuinely contentious. And it took fourteen years. This guide does not pretend the win was quick, cheap, or won on the planning merits. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — a development refused on planning or ecological grounds where possible, and, where the planning battle is lost, a treasured place bought out and restored — through the planning system, the Assembly, the Trust, and the island's love of its coast, with the patience Plémont demanded.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here as Plémont did — by combining a sustained community coalition, the political route through the Assembly, and, above all, the buyout-and-restoration a conservation trust can lead. Fight the development on planning and ecological grounds first; work the States Assembly for a better outcome or public funding; and, if the planning battle is lost, pursue the acquisition — through the National Trust for Jersey, public funds, and fundraising — that can save a treasured place even after consent, and return it to nature.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Jersey is an open, hopeful setting — a close-knit island democracy with a strong National Trust, an accessible legislature, and a deep love of its coast, and a proven win in Plémont. But honesty about how that win came is the first discipline. The planning fight can be lost — at Plémont it was. The buyout that

saved the headland cost over eight million pounds, half of it contentious public money, and took fourteen years. This was not quick, cheap, or won on the planning merits. So aim at the winnable — a development refused where possible, and, where planning is lost, a place bought out and restored — with the coalition, the Assembly, the Trust, and the patience the fight demands.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Jersey development runs through a small island's institutions. The **planning authority and the Minister for the Environment** decide applications, with an objections and public-inquiry process. The **States Assembly** — accessible and able to vote public funds — is a real political route, as it was for Plémont. The **National Trust for Jersey** can acquire and hold land. And the **courts** review the legality. Map who decides an application's fate, and where the Assembly and the Trust can act, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A development needs planning permission, with an objections stage and, for a significant scheme, a public inquiry. That is your first entry point: the moment to object, document the ecological and coastal harm, and press for refusal. But Plémont's lesson is that the story does not end at consent: the States Assembly can be worked for a better outcome or funding, and, above all, the National Trust can pursue a buyout-and-restoration that saves the place even after planning is lost. Enter at the objections stage — and be ready to keep going.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the permission: where an application stands, and whether it has cleared its objections and inquiry. Follow the ecology: whether the site holds scarce coast, protected habitat, or a colony like Plémont's puffins. Follow the funds: whether the States can be moved to help fund a purchase, and what fundraising and Trust acquisition could achieve. The leverage lies in the planning objections, the ecological designations, the Assembly, and the buyout.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Jersey has real watchers: the planning authority and the Minister for the Environment, the objections and inquiry process, the States Assembly, the National Trust for Jersey, the courts, a free press, and a close-knit, engaged public. These genuinely function, and a case is built to engage them — and, where the planning battle is lost, to turn to the Assembly and the Trust, as Plémont did.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Opposition in Jersey is genuinely capable of winning — Plémont saved a headland even after consent was granted. The single most decisive move is **combining the sustained community campaign with the buyout-and-restoration the National Trust can lead**, because on a small island the planning battle may be lost, but a treasured place can still be acquired and returned to nature. The planning objections and ecological designations are the first line; the States Assembly the political route; the Trust and the buyout the distinctive, decisive lever; the island's love of its coast the fire. What the tools deliver is real — a development refused, or a place bought out and restored — though, as Plémont shows, it can cost millions and take years.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the development over a scarce coast, field, or green space. **Where is it in planning?** — at objections, inquiry, or already consented. **What is the ecology?** — the habitat, colony, or coastal value that grounds an objection or a conservation case. **Can the Assembly help?** — with a better outcome or public funding. **Is a buyout possible?** — through the Trust, public funds, and fundraising. Pick the fight where the planning or ecological handle is clearest — and, if planning may be lost, where a buyout could still save the place.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm and the ecology** — the scarce coast, field, or habitat at stake, the colony or protected feature, and what the development would destroy. **Layer two: the process and the standard** — where the application stands, its ecological assessment, and the planning grounds for objection. **Layer three: the coalition and the buyout** — the community and Trust to mobilise, the Assembly route, and the acquisition-and-restoration path if planning is lost. A case that grounds the planning and ecological objection and, in reserve, maps the buyout route is one Jersey's institutions and community take seriously — as Plémont proved.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the application and plans, the scarce coast or habitat, the colony or protected feature, what would be lost. Gather the **process record**: the planning stage, the objections window, the inquiry, the ecological assessment. Gather the **Assembly record**: the political route, the potential for public funding. Gather the **buyout record**: the Trust's capacity, the fundraising, the acquisition path. Jersey's small scale and open institutions make much of this genuinely obtainable.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Plémont's method — a sustained community coalition around a treasured place, spanning years — is the model. Build with the **National Trust for Jersey**, whose acquisition power is the distinctive lever; the **community and islanders**, roused by love of the scarce coast; the **States members** who can carry the political route; and the **ecological and legal experts** who can ground the objection and the case. On a close-knit island, a treasured coast can rouse the whole public — as Plémont did for fourteen years — so make the shared, scarce commons the heart of the coalition.

STEP 4: PLANNING, THE ASSEMBLY & THE BUYOUT — SAVING A PLACE EVEN AFTER CONSENT

Set expectations honestly: here the levers are real and proven, in an open democracy, though the planning fight can be lost and the buyout is costly and slow.

The Planning and Ecological Objection

The first line is the **planning objections and public-inquiry process** and the **ecological assessment and designations** — the scarce coast, the protected habitat, the colony. Object, ground the harm, and press for refusal. But, as Plémont shows, be ready for the possibility that this battle is lost.

The States Assembly

The **States Assembly** is an accessible political route: it can be worked for a better outcome, and — decisively at Plémont — it can vote public funds toward a purchase. A community that engages its States members can shift a decision or unlock the funding a buyout needs.

The National Trust and the Buyout-and-Restoration

The distinctive, decisive lever is the **National Trust for Jersey and the buyout-and-restoration** it can lead: a conservation body that can acquire and hold land can save a site even one with planning consent — buying it, demolishing, and returning it to nature. Pursued together — the planning and ecological objection, the Assembly, and the Trust's buyout — these levers can save a treasured place, on the planning merits or, as at Plémont, in spite of losing them.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the planning authority:** here is a scarce coast or habitat, and the ecological and planning grounds for refusal. **For the States Assembly:** here is a treasured place worth a better outcome — or worth public funds to acquire, as Plémont was. **For the National Trust:** here is a site to acquire, hold, and restore. **For the public:** here is one of the island's finest places, which once built over will never return. **The golden rule:** fight the planning and ecological case first, work the Assembly, and, if planning is lost, pursue the buyout-and-restoration through the Trust — the fight is not over at consent.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

On a close-knit island with a free press, media is central — it sustained Plémont for fourteen years. Frame the story around **the treasured, scarce commons:** a coast, a headland, a green space the whole island loves, and a development that would take it. Carry it through the Jersey press, the National Trust's networks, and the island's engaged public. A few cautions: keep it accurate and grounded in the planning and ecological case; where planning is lost, pivot the story to the buyout and the chance to restore the place; and let the scarcity, the ecology, and the island's love of its coast carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in the planning and ecological case, and ready to turn to the buyout.

8A — To the planning authority: object to the application, set out the ecological and coastal harm, and request refusal.

8B — On the ecology: flag the habitat, colony, or coastal designation the development threatens.

8C — To a States member: set out the treasured place and press for a better outcome or public funding.

8D — To the States Assembly: make the case for public funds toward a purchase, as at Plémont.

8E — To the National Trust for Jersey: propose the acquisition, demolition, and restoration of the site.

8F — On the fundraising: launch the public appeal to raise the community's share of a buyout.

8G — To the courts (through counsel): where warranted, challenge a flawed planning decision.

8H — To the press and public: rouse the island around the treasured commons, and — if planning is lost — the buyout that can still save it.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: find the application and its stage; document the ecological and coastal value; write the one-page objection and the public appeal. **The fastest-moving levers:** the planning objections, the States Assembly, and the National Trust. **Emergency action:** if consent is granted, remember Plémont — turn at once to the Assembly and the Trust, and map the buyout-and-restoration route. Throughout, rouse the island around the treasured, scarce commons.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Even in a strong island democracy the field can tilt: housing pressure, a developer with consent. Recognise it, and lean on the levers the tilt cannot escape — the planning and ecological objections, the accessible States Assembly, and, above all, the National Trust's buyout-and-restoration that can save a place even after planning is lost. Plémont proved it. Accept, honestly, that it can be costly — over eight million pounds — and slow — fourteen years — and that public funding for a purchase is genuinely contentious.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Jersey is a rule-of-law island democracy, so the more usual challenge is legitimate development pressure rather than outright capture. Where a decision is pushed against the public interest or the process, respond through the strong channels Jersey genuinely provides: the planning objections and inquiry, the States Assembly, the National Trust, the free press, the engaged public, and the courts. **On safety:** Jersey is a safe, rule-of-law democracy, so the risks here are political and financial, not physical; the work is open, lawful, and public. Keep it grounded in the planning and ecological case and the treasured commons, and be ready to turn to the buyout if planning is lost.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel. The documented harm feeds the planning objection, the ecological case, and — in reserve — the buyout route; the community and Trust mobilise around the commons; the Assembly route runs alongside; the media sustains the campaign. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and file the objections; **months two onward**, press the inquiry, work the Assembly, and rouse the public; **if planning is lost**, turn to the buyout — the Trust, the public funds, the fundraising — and the restoration, over the years it may take, as Plémont did. The core discipline: planning- and ecology-grounded first, then the Assembly and the buyout, and patient throughout.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposition in Jersey is genuinely capable of winning, because it is a close-knit island democracy with a strong National Trust, an accessible legislature, an independent legal system, and a deep love of its coast — and a proven win in Plémont, where a headland cleared for houses became a wild, open place for everyone. This guide has been honest that the win came in a particular way: the planning fight was lost, and the community saved the place not on the planning merits but by buying it — a route that required over eight

million pounds, half of it contentious public money, and took fourteen years. But that honest truth is the guide's central lesson, not its limit. A community that fights the planning and ecological case first, works the States Assembly, and — if planning is lost — pursues the buyout-and-restoration the National Trust for Jersey can lead, rousing the island around a scarce and treasured commons, can genuinely save a place even after consent is granted. The tools are real and proven, and Plémont's deepest lesson is that on a small island, the fight is not over when planning is lost — a treasured headland can still be bought back, cleared, and returned to nature, forever.